Urban culture.
A plea for urban studies beyond disciplinary constraints

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Creatively underestimated urban culture

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When views on urban cultural issues are discussed at different urban studies oriented universities, the criticism often is that culture here denotes an outdated, elitist concept that harks back to a high culture schema (Schulze, 2001) and thus primarily takes into account a privileged, aesthetically-minded audience (Heidenreich 1998).

In the wake of the fading euphoria about the creative city, especially surrounding policy programs under the 'Creative City Policy', however, criticism of more recent concepts is also clearly increasing (Raunig 2007; Ponzini/Rossi 2009). For the intensification of urban policy priorities on (apparently) creative urban middle classes, who often come from a creditworthy and academically influenced milieu, seems to exclude many facets and potentials of creativity on a small scale and from low-threshold everyday culture, or primarily to prime the pump to secure economic prosperity.

> "Through the functionalization of culture as a means to realize economic objectives, the city would be deprived of it [...] in two ways: it originates outside, and it aims toward the outside. As a means for the purpose of attraction in the original sense of the word, urban culture confronts an audience that has increasingly less in common with the inhabitants. In this way the view of urban culture narrows to the representable, the marketable, and the medially presentable."(Musner 2009: 35, referring to Lindner 2000: 259, translated from German).

Far from the traditional goals of socio-spatial justice and emancipation in 80
contemporary, capitalist-dominated cities, this sort of urban revitalization often does not result in any direct or immediate benefits for the local population, but rather the opposite: for many people the rent and cost of living in these creative quarters increases as a result (cf. Ponzini / Rossi 2009: 18). Although the situation in Vienna is certainly different from that in the case study of Baltimore, the academic proponents of such policies can no longer evade the persistent criticism that these discourses also function as an instrument for exhibiting the top-down culturalization of stigmatized "problem areas" in the wake of urban policy that is increasingly business-friendly.

Even in the context of critical urban studies that see the history of development of (European) cities in their many material and symbolic facets as places of emancipatory social forces (Siebel 2004), studies that are based solely on culture as a productive factor fall short. For these reasons, it seems imperative that the changing debates about culture are addressed with a view

to current, culturally specific approaches to spatial theory and urban research. For 'urban culture' wins thematically in urban studies reflections on relevance, in order to adequately question and understand contemporary phenomena and challenges of urban development beyond just the discourses on creativity. In the course of significant international mobility and demographic changes (e.g., negative growth, population explosion, aging, changing family patterns and lifestyles), urban development policy is increasingly being confronted with changing societal needs.

The methodological anchoring of the examination of cultural aspects in urban research holds potential for boundary-crossing multi-causal analysis of the city as a research object, acting as a medium between concrete micro-sociology and abstract macro-theory. Here, local researchers are called upon to broaden their (narrow) perspectives on the expansive implications of possible global transformations and thus to master a methodological balancing act beyond globalist and localist breaking points (cf. Gualini 2005: 299). Operationalization or breaking down complex issues into clear methodological steps then seems insincere, however, if the choice of tools does not come spontaneously from a specific problem area in urban development, but rather is predetermined a priori by disciplinary tool kits. Thus, some research topics are formulated on the basis of the available tools, or
problem areas are tailored such that the established methodology seems to be applicable.

This type of research approach ignores the most striking characteristics of the subject of urban studies, namely understanding the city simultaneously as a multi-layered, socio-historical process, which likewise includes the production of knowledge, materiality, and meaning (Lefebvre 1998). The second trait is that urban researchers are essentially never able to factor themselves out of their field of study, because with few exceptions they themselves take part in everyday urban life with its opportunities and dilemmas. In view of these aspects – multidimensional understanding and participatory research – reflections in connection with urban culture now appear to be methodologically groundbreaking, as the approaches of the early Chicago School of Urban Ethnography have shown for example. Due to the need to work through knowledge gaps between empirical and theoretical research productively, including at the micro-social level, much urban research today in the area of midrange theory is located at the meso level. Here, experimental thinking in amorphous and dynamic areas of tension is superimposed on traditional linear emblematization in old dichotomies. The local and global no longer seem to be separable in a clear-cut and two-dimensional way; the clear and rapid evaluation of results yields dialectical approaches to thinking of the city in its (in)visible characteristics as product, process, and producer at the same time. The city as socio-historical process is compact complexity in the smallest space, and is concrete as well as abstract. The city is therefore a clear and tangible opportunity for the scientific study of change in societal reality and projection. For researchers, the city is a potpourri of biography and autobiography, so to speak.

The sciences that deal with the city empirically are heterogeneous by nature. Urban cultural research deals critically with heterogeneity not only in terms of content and methodology, however, but also epistemologically. Here,

it becomes apparent how the nature of the subject diffuses into the character of the working principles. However, this obvious connection seems to have been starkly underappreciated in the debates in urban studies about the unique characteristics of certain dominant disciplines and in the dialogue in the course of the acquisition of knowledge across disciplines. This paper thus represents a movement to seek the potential of urban culture as a possible catalyst of multiple starting points for an exploration of the city in its everyday realities in a manner that cuts across disciplinary boundaries. It concludes with an open plea for a postdisciplinary positioning in empirical urban research. First, however, an exemplary review of some of the forerunners of contemporary debates is necessary to understand the current significance of urban-cultural considerations as part of a more complete evolutionary history.

Urban culture as a mosaic of social realities

> "The city is the greatest reification of culture (...), the largest mirror in which human culture can be recognized and contemplated. It is created and developed through interstructuring different cultural forms and meanings. (...) The city itself is the originator of cultural meanings. (...) The city takes on externally created cultural patterns and transforms them" (Heidenreich 1998: 223, translated from German).

In 1998, Heidenreich wrote a "plea for a cultural studies perspective on the city," in which she first recognizes a narrowing of the term “culture” and its considerations in sociology and secondly, based on a cultural-theoretical analysis of its history as a word, describes first its application in the natural sciences, and later its detachment and transformation in the field of the humanities:

> "Sense-based understanding of actions and cultural products and the exploration of their meanings took the place of the naturalistic-causal or economic-causal derivation and explanation of culture – and optimistic evolutionary or revolutionary hope for the future was replaced by a more thoughtful attitude. The sociology of Max Weber and Georg Simmel is included in this delimiting movement" (Heidenreich 1998: 221).

With various historical layers of meaning of the term “culture”, according to the author’s core message, a task of social agency is addressed that is achieved by the phenomenon of culture in different fields. As a mediator, the city acts as a "cultural institution," as a "powerful reification of culture" (ibid.: 223f, referring to Simmel, 1984).

Simmel is also a reference point in studies grounded in biographies of the profession via one of the central protagonists of the Chicago School of Urban Ethnography: Robert Ezra Park. Thus this school of thought was not only programmatically oriented toward urban culture as its central subject, but was also intertwined with it in various ways (cf. Lindner 2004: 128f). Studies in this tradition are ideally works that "try to understand social worlds and institutions in large cities in a detailed and elaborate way using an impressive

variety of approaches " (ibid.: 142). In "The Discovery of Urban Culture" and "Walks on the Wild Side: A History of Urban Research" Lindner (2004, 2007) emphatically argues for the special status of Park as a leading figure in the early Chicago School of urban sociology, which he sees as one of the most important trends to date in urban research. During a semester abroad in Berlin around 1900, Park was inspired by Simmel and his attitude, "[…] to find society sensu strictissimo […] where several individuals interact (for, with, or against one another)" (Simmel, 1931: 2, quoted in Lindner 2004: 121, translated from German). He followed his teacher in understanding large cities not only in terms of alienation, as was usual at the time, but in terms of emancipation: [...] with him alienation takes the form of a crisis that ultimately proves to be fruitful" (ibid.) Lindner therefore situates the discovery of urban culture in urban ethnographic research. At the same time he ascribes to the Chicago School a closeness to intuitively chosen methodological approaches that are reflected in the practices of other professional fields, such as journalistic reportage. He does not interpret the absence of a rigid set of research tools as a deficiency because this would be tantamount to an inadequate positivist critique of qualitative research paths. Lindner (2007: 10) sees in this absence "an indication of a particular approach," as sociological imagination is characteristic of the Chicago School's urban research (Lindner 2004:. 140f, translated from German).

A delicate sense for developing urban research therefore involves looking behind the curtain to see preconceived opinions, public scenes, and private facades, metaphorically speaking to lift the veil, to first develop an eye for the unique characteristics of the large city (ibid.: 116). Generated in Chicago, the rather unconventional approaches to exploring the "mosaic of urban life worlds", their movement towards a broad concept of urban culture as an "ensemble [...] of solidified attitudes and feelings, which are reflected in habits and passed on through traditions" (Park 1925: 1, cited in Lindner 2007: 323f., translated from German) make possible a spatial "analysis of the interplay between physical structure and cultural order" (Lindner 2004: 126, translated from German). Thus, already at the beginning of the 20th century, the foundation was laid for an urban cultural research that, although disciplinarily positioned according to background, looked away from traditional disciplinary boundaries in its field of action. This was grounded in an epistemological motivation for an undisguised subject: urban life worlds in their originality, interactions, and fullness. Spatio-theoretically, the Chicago School would be interpreted as a "unity of territory and expansion [...] and unity between geographical containers and social identity" (Frey 2009: 101, referring to Löw, 2001: 48ff., translated from German). A century later, such an approach does not seem any less current at a time of habitual departmental logics, of the disciplinary strains surrounding the main academic venues of urban research and, furthermore, of partly exclusive bourgeois notions of culture.

Urban culture as contemporary controversy in architecture and planning

Musner (2009: 27ff) refers to the "model of the European city with its trinity of civic emancipation, cultural diversity, and economic innovation," which in the contemporary, non-locationally specific approaches of international urban

research alone is still considered to be "a historically and culturally isolated special case in a globe-spanning spectrum of very different forms of urbanity" (translated from German). He criticizes non context specific urban studies approaches for this reason because they view "urban culture primarily in a functionalist way" with reference to increasing societal polarization between

> "wealthy, highly skilled, cosmopolitan elites, who are confronted with […] a growing number of 'working poor' – low-paid and less qualified service workers". "Thus, at most, at the level of representation the lifestyles, medial articulations, and material culture of the service and information society as well as the pluralism of the immigrant culture are reflected, but less so the reserves, mentalities, and traditions as well as the concepts of space that result from the history of a metropolis" (ibid.).

Such generalizations about a "global standard metropolis" and thus

> "a representation of the city as an arbitrarily fillable container space that can be equipped with contents and strategically marketed without consideration of the locality and history",

are based on a too "narrow and instrumental understanding of 'urban culture'" (ibid.: 31f., referring to Lindner 2000, translated from German).

In architecture and planning – in addition to the debates on planning cultures (Knieling/Othengrafen 2009) and on building culture (Durth/Sigel 2009) – many practitioners often harbor the fear that the new relevance of urban cultural aspects will be accompanied by an overemphasis on the intangible dimensions of urban development. Such a theoretically and abstractly chosen focus emphasizes the development of discursive images, associative attributions of meaning, identifying potential, and communication strategies in space far from structural interventions, far from the material practice with which architects and planners are involved on a daily basis. From other camps, the criticism is well known that architecture has however become an "inventor of a new urban culture" (cf. Hannemann/Sewing 1998: 58, translated from German), but without taking into account evolutionary aspects of society and thus cultural authenticity. Frey (2009: 141, translated from German) states that urban planning tries to "activate the cultural capital of the residents and establish it instrumentally for an economic renewal process." Several of these approaches have in common that they find in the discourse surrounding urban culture either phenomena of loss, appropriations, or restrictions. Few researchers explicitly grapple with the diverse potential of urban cultural considerations in a systematic way.

This concise grouping of different positions makes no claim to completeness or general applicability; quite the opposite. It shows that in most cases ambivalent, contradictory thematic content is included with urban cultural considerations. This seems to cause discontent and unease among many colleagues and experts. The question is asked whether the heterogeneity of approaches and thematic foci do not at the same time harbor a way to recognize a sphere in which the productive crossing of boundaries between

partly hardened positions is possible. This idea is based on the following remarks.

As previously outlined, the multi-dimensionality of different perspectives, the methodological pluralism that culture-oriented approaches to spatial theoretical debates within urban research can systematically make possible seems to be rather underappreciated in the context of the theoretical controversy surrounding 'urban culture', which is fueled from many disciplinary perspectives. Now however there are groundbreaking new orientations with regard to the potential of the "spatial turn" (Bachmann-Medick 2009, translated from German) in cultural studies, which appear to be theoretically, methodologically, and epistemologically productive. This is about the mosaic of social worlds, viewed under a magnifying glass of unconventional ethnographic approaches. These focus on the micro level of social life patterns in their fullness and allow for the investigation of the peculiarities and idiosyncrasies of lived space. It is also about multi-dimensional approaches to complex processes of urban production between the dimensions of spatial observation (e.g., between micro-, meso-, and macro focus; between conceived, perceived, and lived spaces; between material and symbolic dimensions), where old dichotomies and linearities are seen as ambivalent and dynamic fields of tension and at the same time as obstructive, overlapping, or penetrating processes.

Relational conceptions of space, diversity of perspectives and societal transfer processes

Recent approaches in human geography not only delineate their subject matter relatively openly, but refer to discipline-crossing approaches immanent in cultural studies:

> "[…] already the specific disciplinary approaches and fields of study as well as their subjects themselves [are] addressed very differently from the outset [...]. Seeking connections between the individual disciplines will be essential: productive blurring of boundaries, opening toward international research directions, recognition of the diversity of perspectives, and dedication to research fields that cut across disciplines. In this sense cultural studies are [...] a medium of understanding in order to 'dialogize' the heterogeneous, highly specialized, mutually insulated outcomes of the sciences, to make structural similarities transparent" (Bachmann-Medick 2009: 12, translated from German).

The relevance of such approaches for urban studies can be identified with reference to relational theories of space, because

> "such a complex operational concept of space leads the spatial turn [...] on the one hand on the track of a political spatial perspective and spatial policy, insofar as it offers itself as an indispensable concept of order given the contingencies of the global world. On the other hand, it draws attention back to specific spatial relationships [...]" (ibid.: 304).

Within these remarks, culture is very much understood as Lefebvre's (1998) "production of space", seemingly as a symbolic and material "transfer process", "that 'translates' the social into the symbolic and in this way imparts in it a texture":

> "Thus the polyphony of spaces comes sharply into view: the linkage of local activities and social relationships with enrollments through emotions, memories, stories, physical and mental appropriations, mental maps and struggles for meaning – far beyond the mere setting of action"(Bachmann-Medick 2009: 304, referring to Rodman n.d.).

This paper therefore calls for a multi-dimensional approach in urban studies, the novelty of which in architecture and planning departments could be to integrate urban culture not only as a historical and contemporary topic of empirical research about cities, but to make fruitful newer cultural studies approaches to spatial theory also in terms of their methodological and epistemological potential. This is representative of an understanding of urbanism that is not about a set-in-stone professional disciplinary discourse with regard to a clearly defined subject. Rather, it aims to move current urban phenomena, problem areas, and dimensions of thinking to the center of a variety of disciplinary perspectives, but without thereby formulating a holistic and implicitly positivist claim to knowledge, as Lefebvre (2003) and several representatives of social scientific approaches assumed.

The urban phenomenon and the old criticism of interdisciplinarity

> "This complexity makes interdisciplinary cooperation essential. The urban phenomenon, taken as a whole, cannot be grasped by any specialized science [...] How many of us are unaware of the disappointments and setbacks of so-called multi- or interdisciplinary efforts? The illusions of such studies, and the myths surrounding them, have been abundantly criticized. [...] While it is true that the urban phenomenon, as a global reality, is in urgent need of people who can pool fragmentary bits of knowledge, the achievement of such a goal is difficult or impossible" (Lefebvre 2003: 53ff.)

The difficult scientific handling of the city as subject in the social sciences, to further follow Lefebvre's remarks, on the one hand lies in the universality of the urban phenomenon. On the other hand the division of labor in the organization of the sciences and thus the instrumentalization and institutionalization of philosophy contribute to the efforts of mental production processes, in consequence leading to a fragmented disciplinary knowledge that separates the subject from its context and thus from its conflicted relationship to social reality. Third, societal reality changes every day, while researchers only have available a particular window of time and limited economic research resources. The call for interdisciplinarity can thus become a dogma by allowing for the formulation of a totalitarian cognitive approach for the urban phenomenon in its universality in a positivistic way under the pretense of wanting to bring fragmented knowledge together. According to Lefebvre, this approach cannot do justice to the context-specific

and process nature of the ambivalent phenomenon. Radical criticism in the sense of a metaphilosophy appears possible, however, if it is initially positioned at the rigid division of labor in science and philosophy, in order to overcome the dogmatism of fragmented sciences "and their pretension to comprehend and clarify everything" in favor of a methodological and theoretical relativism and an epistemological pluralism. "No method can ensure absolute 'scientificity', whether theoretical or practical, especially in sociology (whether urban or not)" (ibid.: 65f.). Here, a complex and critical perspective is sharpened which includes the structural power relations manifested in the institutions as well as the empathetic qualities of lived life, among other dimensions, without laying a totalitarian claim to a holistic covering of all possible dimensions of thinking and analysis. This is not achievable and also not desirable. Lefebvre thus does not turn against the complex conception of city as societal reality, quite the opposite: his emphasis is on a relational, dialectical approach of an epistemological understanding of the urban phenomenon with respect to its complex and sometimes contradictory, but in any case constantly changing nature. But how should a scientific approach result from this?

> "This would require a change in our ideas about education, for such a discipline would be based not on a body of acquired knowledge [...] that it can dispense but on a problematic" (Lefebvre 2003: 55).

Although Lefebvre continued here by speaking of "one such discipline", in light of the context it is more an attitude in the sense of an individual or institutional positioning that is meant here. What the author clearly underscores is the concern that the subject ‘city’ or, more precisely, the urban phenomenon, must be explored due to acute problems areas (problematiques).

With an eye to current urban development, complex changes have occurred at the boundary lines of traditional (thought) structures at times of post-Fordist transformation. At an epistomological level the changes also involve the experts and colleagues at the universities who, oriented toward research applications, not only decorate themselves with the feathers of interdisciplinarity or with a particular disciplinary affiliation from a subject’s cultural pathos, but consequently put to the test, reject, or methodologically accumulate traditional epistemological approaches. Finally, the approach results in the subject being constructed/constituted, although it is still extremely ambivalent in theory and practice, as shown above. But is it not precisely the genuine characteristic of urban research to derive from the intrinsic nature of the subject the ways and means of exploring it? Exactly to that point, is it not a fundamental analysis of space, epistemology, and action that has led Lefebvre's writings to again be in demand in urban research? But how can these strands of thought be operationalized in contemporary social research in order to achieve empirically thick analysis (thick description), and hence full-bodied qualitative statements about the connections between the little visible mechanisms of urban production and the visible transformation of urban realities, if it (as indicated in the quote above) requires a change in our ideas in education?

Action research – Systematic changes in perspective and reciprocal positioning

I believe that such a research approach is located less in the area of well-known ex-post studies within qualitative social research about cities, but seeks its methodological inspiration in the action and reflection fields of the present-oriented 'action research' family. Action research is not new, but it claims to position the role of researchers in a different light (McNiff/Whitehead 2006). It is important to again make visible the hidden rifts between reality and interpretation, between theory and practice, bridging them when possible and demystifying the supposed brilliance of the academic ivory tower. The closeness in terms of content between action research and classical empirical social research is obvious, but their differences are also evident: where the latter is typically clearly distanced from the object of study – the 'acting sujets' (Schmid 2005) – and therefore also known as "spectactor research" or "outsider research", in the former the researchers are explicitly involved in the social context from which they would otherwise like to be excluded. "Action researchers, however, are insider researchers. They see themselves as part of the situation [...]" (ibid.: 8). As Tornaghi (2010: 35) observes, ethical approaches in urban research are largely due to the culturally determined morals and values of the researchers. Participatory approaches in action research therefore demand, with a relative openness of methodology, the critical self-reflective clarification of the positioning of the researchers with a view toward different roles and identities as well as a reflection on how these affect encounters, processes, and results within the research process (ibid.: 37): "Accessing a lived space is a social act that creates a reaction, mobilizes emotions, negotiates identities and establishes power relations" (ibid.: 38). It is ultimately the moral and ethical responsibility of researchers to develop emotional abilities in addition to rational analysis and bring a willingness to be an agent for the transmission of desires, emotions, visions and expectations (ibid.: 39). Such an attitude is to be understood as a positioning also in terms of urban studies culture, which captures the (urban) cultural influences of the researcher and the people involved in the research process in terms of the role of culture as an intermediary.

The main claim that the circumstances of everyday action should be actively reflected upon and changed is at the same time open to vehement criticism, which sees in this type of hybrid approach the blurring of the necessary boundaries between science, activism, and ideology. However, knowledge production is per se ideologically colored (Lefebvre, 2003). It is therefore much more important how transparently and openly researchers own value systems are explained in the research process and how clearly the obvious limitations of the action research approach are presented. Another critical objection to action research emphasizes the risk of hastily reducing complex social problems into concrete solvable contexts of action and thereby neglecting possible structural influences. Therefore, it is necessary to mitigate the weaknesses of action research by employing a distanced, spatio-theoretically sound analysis of structural dilemmas. Triangulation would therefore not only be necessary here on the methodological level but also at the level of research approach in order to offset the weaknesses of one with the strengths of the other. The strengths of action research lie in the possibility

of dialogic learning within circular research processes: participants and researchers can ideally acquire knowledge about which material, symbolic and socio-historical contexts have influenced their practice and to what extent. Similarly, in addition to reflection on the activities, the focus is on changes in the social world through one's own actions. Action research thus overcomes the lethargy and backward-oriented rigidity of structural criticism that in some places has become almost pathological, and which has retreated into abstract levels of discourse. On the other hand, proponents of action research cannot under any circumstances deny structural societal dilemmas. Here, it is necessary to iteratively thematize the limits and possibilities of their own actions and the further implications for the research field in a circular research process and, if necessary, to adjust them.

The relationship between the methodological and epistemological qualities of urban culture and the potential of action research as the basis of research design lies in the research ethics emphasis on perspective and position, because multiple changes of perspective and research ethical positionality will be systematically made possible. With *perspective*, the gaining of scientific insights in the epistemological processes of mental production is meant, while position refers to the emotional learning of a capacity for empathy. Positions and changes in perspective in action research follow the interplay between action and reflection, and therefore an ongoing process of awareness (also of one's own) values, morals, and cultural backgrounds in the dynamic research process. This approach allows for the analytical support, critical reflection, and active change from traditional approaches in urban research in the process of their creation by participants and researchers on the one hand and the partial change of specific problem fields in cities on the other hand, because

> "what would be the point of critical reason if it bore no direct relation to practical politics? In theory, critical reason is not obliged to be immediately useful. In practice, though, its purpose may seem obscure. Lack of dialogue between thinkers and doers is annoying for those who put practice before theory: it is also frustrating for those who put theory before practice" (McGuighan 1996: 1).

Dialogue between theory and practice (transdisciplinarity) is therefore required on the one hand; on the other hand, as evidenced in this volume, it calls for a dialogue between the disciplines of urban research (interdisciplinary). How exactly do the terms differ, and furthermore what is offered by juggling with another concept of cooperation in urban research: that of postdisciplinarity?

Principles of action beyond disciplinary constraints. Perception of the world and choice of lenses

> "The identification which so many academics have with their disciplines is actually counterproductive in relation to making progress in understanding society. In the first place, disciplines are parochial: their members tend to be incapable of seeing beyond the questions posed by their own discipline, which provide an all-purpose filter for

> everything. Where the identity and boundaries of a discipline are strongly asserted and policed, it can stifle scholarship and innovation. [...] Secondly, disciplines are also often imperialist: they attempt to claim territories occupied by others as their own" (Sayer 2001: 83).

Apart from Sayer (1999), who wrote the paper "Long Live Postdisciplinary Studies! Sociology and the curse of disciplinary parochialism / imperialism," Jessop and Sum (2004) have also worked on the theme "On pre- and postdisciplinarity in (Cultural) Political Economy" (Table 1). While interdisciplinarity and transdisciplinarity are presented in a category as approaches tailored to selective topics that appear to be compatible with the conceptual framework of various disciplines, according to Sum and Jessop postdisciplinary approaches are about the detection of specific problem areas, regardless of how different disciplines or societal groups formulate, conceptualize, or classify them. In a broader sense this corresponds to Lefebvre's required orientation on a problematique from the empirical reality of the city.

Table 1: Overview of different forms of disciplinarity (Sum / Jessop 2004: 23, referring to Jessop 2003). 94

	Thematic Concerns	**Methodological Approach**	**Epistemic and Ontological Outlook**	**Extent and Form of Scientific Reflexivity**
Pre-Disciplinary Period	Focuses on holistic, multifaceted themes. Analyses predate the rise of distinct academic disciplines	Polymathic, holistic, and integrative methodologies, often with humanistic as well as positivistic aspects	Tied to a world with low functional differentiation. So society-nature-cosmos often seen as integrated under God or by natural laws	Tends to naturalize a holistic world and hence tends to assert need to study it from all available perspectives
Disciplinary	Focuses exclusively on themes that are identified in terms of categories of a given discipline; so it ignores all other aspects of an entity and other possible themes	Approach to any theme is based on categories of a given discipline. Can prompt efforts to colonize other disciplines through disciplinary imperialism.	Distinct disciplines correspond to the structure of the real world – each set of ontological entities has its own discipline	Tends to naturalize respective disciplinary objects of analysis as real world entities and so does not reflect on the constructed nature of disciplines
Multi- or Pluri-Disciplinary	Focuses on themes located at the intersection of the categories of two or more conventional disciplines	Combines approaches from these disciplines to produce a simple *additive* account of the chosen topic	Conventional disci-plines correspond to simple and/or emergent entities in the real world. By combining them, one can understand a complex world	Aware of *epistemic* limits of disciplines and of resulting need to combine them to get a 'complete' account
Inter- or trans-Disciplinary	Focuses on selected topics or themes that are compatible with categories of several disciplines	Combines approaches from these disciplines to produce more complex account	Objects are always complex and cannot be understood just by adding together a series of given disciplines	Aware of *ontological* limits of disciplines and of resulting need to combine them to get better accounts
Post-Disciplinary	Identifies and studies specific problems independently of how different disciplines would classify them, if at all	Draws on and/or develops concepts and methodologies suited to problem(s) without regard to specific disciplinary proprieties. Often develops new concepts not rooted in any 'discipline'.	World is descript-ively inexhaustible and nomically complex. Study it in terms of problems that are constructed for specific research purposes	Critically self-aware of epistemic and ontological limits of inherited disciplines and of resulting need to follow problems
Anti-Disciplinary	Reject the idea that there are clearly identifiable themes open to discipline-based research	"Anything goes"	Real world is one of largely unstructured complexity, chaos and even catastrophe	Disciplines are socially constructed and arbitrary

However, Sum and Jessop are unspecific about the separation between interdisciplinarity and transdisciplinarity. Their approach is therefore extended by a paper on transdisciplinarity by Novy (2010) where interdisciplinarity means the methodologically and disciplinarily located bringing together of partial knowledge from different disciplines with regard to a phenomenon, transdisciplinarity is about the exchange between different fields of knowledge in theory (academic knowledge) and practice (professional knowledge) – and thus also between planners at universities and planners in offices or in the local community (ibid.). A third field is the everyday knowledge that everyone has regardless of his professional 95

background or institutional affiliation. This ordinarily refers to the context-specific knowledge of the citizens, residents, and visitors in a neighborhood in Berlin or Vienna, for example, about the local site, its actors and processes, its mores, traditions, and customs, which however many educated experts in urban planning, design, and research possess in ever smaller amounts due to the increasing globalization of their spheres of action. In the course of processes of soft urban development, at a given state of technical progress in the knowledge society, the potential of e-democracy tools for the integration of locally rooted everyday knowledge with the specific perspectives and particular positions of the residents and visitors appears to be starkly underappreciated. This discrepancy has contributed to the fact that the current debates about interdisciplinarity have overlapped with those about transdisciplinarity at relevant urban research symposia.[1] It should be noted that these debates often linger in the reflective atmosphere of academic seminar rooms and rarely find their way onto the streets and into the classroom. However, there are several encouraging exceptions.[2]

In contrast to these accounts on transdisciplinarity, postdiciplinarity refers less to opportunities or barriers to thinking in various disciplines or fields of knowledge, but instead to the subject of the city as an urban phenomenon, as a constantly changing societal reality and projection, which cannot be exhaustively or comprehensively comprehended in its full complexity, but can only be understood relationally and contextually on the basis of sharply defined problem areas detected qualitatively in an appropriate manner. Parks' concept of the "mosaic of social realities" is not only applicable here for micro-social, urban ethnographic knowledge acquisition in terms of the convergence and divergence of cultural backgrounds in multiethnic societies, but is expanded in the context of this plea for urban culture as a field of urban studies dedicated to the characteristics of urban societies: the point is to overcome linear, two-dimensional thinking and disciplinarily introverted boundaries in a process and context-oriented way in favor of deliberate intuition and heterogeneity of the exploration of relevant spatial dimensions of the problem. Efforts toward knowledge transfer and related services that the substantive exploration of urban culture as a theme naturally bring with it also deeply penetrate urban research at the methodological and epistemological level. The plea therefore includes demands for crossing boundaries, a diversity of perspectives, and substantive rethinking by way of horizontal creative thinking. Such an approach ideally has as a precondition a priori specified topics and permeates the basis of the current, sometimes acute problem areas that cause the urban phenomenon, also in other fields beyond "urban culture": these could be critical investigations of urban politics, urban form, urban economics, or all relevant aspects that deal with urban society and its

[1] See, for example, “Transdisciplinary Symposium: Social inequality and cultural diversity in European cities”, Social Polis Project WU Vienna and Unequal diversity project, Paulo Freire Center, Austria (Vienna, URL: http://www.socialpolis.eu/index.php?option=com_content&view=article&id=148:transdisciplinary-symposium&catid=113:genreal&Itemid=222) or KU Leuven, Spindus Conference "Epistemology of space and its qualities" (URL: http://www.w-o-mb.be/SPINDUS/download/SPINDUSCONF.pdf) with a section on transdisciplinarity.

[2] Here it is appropriate to mention the approach of the ongoing "Sparkling Science" program of the Austrian Federal Ministry for Science and Research (BMWF), which according to its own description is "an unconventional way of cultivating scientific talent that is unique in Europe" in which researchers work dialogically side-by-side with young people on current scientific projects (URL: http://www.sparklingscience.at). The evaluation of the results of the project remains to be seen, but the approach appears innovative in the sense of the transdisciplinary paradigm.

respective spatial expression. What is relevant is outwardly developed by urban realities and projections and requires that researchers intuitively engage with the diversity of lived spaces in the city and seek to understand the urban phenomenon also far from their own lifestyles, social milieus, and cultural backgrounds. The research agendas are thus constantly regenerated, simultaneously reviewed, enriched, and sharpened. As long as they remain relevant, traditional topics can be put in other contexts, considered against these backgrounds, and interpreted in a differentiated way. New concepts, however, are often only produced in the first place within post-disciplinary studies (Table 1). For these must inevitably be stronger than others with deconstruction and reconstruction of their conceptual building blocks and, if necessary, work with the introduction of new terms in order to do justice to the particular phenomenon or mechanism and the complex relationships between visible and invisible mechanisms of the production of urban space.

It is the basic motivation of advocates to develop postdisciplinary attitudes, concepts, and methods that seem appropriate for the empirical nature of the problems, without necessarily attempting to position their research within a discipline. At this point, the scientistic-sounding demand for postdisciplinary approaches at the methodological level is nothing more than a renewal of the emphatic call for the social scientific imagination, for intuitive, unconventional, and modest approaches, and for the necessity of methodological variation. These steps occur automatically as soon as one delves into the diversity of life worlds and cultural peculiarities in historical and contemporary urban societies. Often these postdisciplinary approaches result in the use of concepts and attitudes that either do not appear to be typically methodologically anchored in any discipline, or that seem to be based in many disciplines.

Even epistemologically boundaries of the different positions arise: while the transdisciplinary and interdisciplinary approaches assume that objects of investigation are complex and that simply adding together different disciplinary perspectives ("pluridisciplinarity" or "multidisciplinarity", Table 1) does not generate new insights, advocates of postdisciplinary research assume that the holistic description of life world(s) is inexhaustible and conceptually difficult to grasp. Here, a surprisingly clear parallel to Lefebvre's criticism of interdisciplinarity comes to light. It is therefore about the scientific construction of the world through concrete problem fields, but nevertheless fully investigating empirically and thus contributing to education in urban studies in a problem-oriented way. Regarding scientific reflexivity, the authors of transdisciplinary and interdisciplinary studies assume that disciplinary considerations imply ontological boundaries, and thus that they should be combined for improved results. Advocates of postdisciplinary positions, however, follow lines of thought that are often self-critical, in which they knowingly thematize ontological and epistemological boundaries of learned disciplinary influences and derive from this the necessity of discovering the dynamics and ambivalence of the subject as a part of it. For this, a diversity of methodologies and perspectives should knowingly be allowed, even though a close linkage between urban culture as a broad field, multi-dimensional method, and epistemological stance is considered to be exceedingly important.

Urban research as postdisciplinary sphere of action per se

With a view toward the manifold approaches in empirical research in practice today, the debate on the relevance of individual disciplinary approaches – "disciplinarity" – seems to be obsolete. Approaches from sociology and political science, in addition to perspectives from anthropology and ethnology, have long since found their way into research and education in architecture and planning departments, and, vice versa, design and planning practices are frequently the subject of studies in the humanities and social sciences. Of course, researchers also encounter limitations when working on plausible, competent, and empirically documented studies between a familiar professional field and new knowledge terrains. More than any other field of investigation, empirical urban development phenomena require a genuine understanding of research that views the social complexity and its spatial manifestations not as separate, but as interrelated. At the same time, the researchers' time and individual readiness to combine old, new, and different perspectives/issues in a complex manner is limited, and is counteracted by the desire for simplification. The call for sound, demonstrable results in a shorter project period overshadows the possibilities for the formation of learning alliances in dialogic learning processes in which "knowledge that enables" (Novy 2010) can arise in an emancipatory way and make the research process socially relevant. Advocates of postdisciplinary positions need to engage more strongly and clearly than their colleagues with the charge of incrementalism and "muddling through", or must deal with multi-layered positions in interpretation and evaluation. In order to be able to effectively argue this point, it would be advisable in the future to more precisely gauge the benefits, limitations, and the advantages and disadvantages of postdisciplinary approaches in urban research. It should be noted, however, that the greatest strength of postdisciplinary approaches in urban research is its inclusive character far from singular demands:

> "The urban phenomenon is universal, which would be sufficient justification for the creation of a university devoted to analytic research on the subject. In doing so, there is no need to insist on absolute priority over other kinds of research and disciplines that are already institutionalized [...]" (Lefebvre 2003: 53f).

Postdisciplinary advances are not about calling the inherent logic of spatial disciplines into question per se, or postulating a scientific trend alongside interdisciplinary and transdisciplinary approachs in a destructive manner. The objectives of this article are rather conceptual sharpening and updating an outlook on a not entirely new terrain of the productive crossing of boundaries in urban studies. The qualitative study of cities as reified and discursive realities will always remain incomplete due to their complexity and the rapid changes in societal reality; researchers are nothing other than "dwarves on the shoulders of giants" (Merton 1980). This finding explicitly raises the last implicit claim of positivist, universal coverage of the research object 'city' and thus emphasizes the relational conceptions of space as a societal process of production molded in form. In the course of contemporary knowledge production, urban studies is an integrating sphere in which urban culture can be used as topic, as method, and can also be sensitively deployed in an epistemological manner.

Urban culture, postdisciplinarity and research

If a plea for urban culture as a postdisciplinary positioning in urban research is to be summarized here, then it would occur against the backdrop of three arguments:

1. **Postdisciplinarity renounces the monopoly claim** because: interdisciplinarity, transdisciplinarity, and postdisciplinarity – three much-used concepts of empirical urban research in recent decades – are not mutually exclusive. When colleagues and staff from different disciplines and educational backgrounds cooperate in teaching, in order to approach a complex phenomenon together with students with cumulative research interests (interdisciplinarity), this can equally be a methodological claim of a strategically forced exchange between theoretical education in the universities and professional practice, rich in inventions and ideas, away from the universities in the cities (transdisciplinarity). At the same time the participants can follow the epistemologically motivated assumption that complexity and ambiguity are inherent in urban production. Researchers and participants could then move away from the limitations of established disciplines and fields of knowledge
   in order to research the phenomenon – their living environment – which is subject to daily change, in its complexity to the greatest extent possible (postdisciplinarity). It is not the view of the city that adapts to the toolbox, but rather the repertoire of tools adapts to the changing city. Similarly, epistemological pitfalls in the fields of tension between interdisciplinarity, transdisciplinarity, and postdisciplinarity are to be addressed openly.

2. **Qualitative empirical urban research in a postdisciplinary manner requires a position** that combines the existence of specialists and generalists and assumes this integrative linkage to be necessary for any advances in insight in urban studies. For specific knowledge is necessary in order to achieve depth of knowledge in detail. General knowledge on the other hand provides breadth of insight and therefore problem-oriented knowledge networking in empiricism and the dialogic production of connectivity in theory. Therefore it is necessary to overcome the "either-or" thinking in traditional or new dichotomies (theory vs. practice, material vs. immaterial, concrete vs. abstract, qualitative vs. quantitative, old methodological hats vs. new methods, etc.) that still exists at many universities in favor of dialectical approaches for the benefit of nuanced thinking in the fields of tension of spatial development. Because the city – whether designed or planned, lived or loved – is a unique window of investigation for cross-references and nuances of complex civic unrest, since they manifest themselves here materially and symbolically in space. The claim of a holistic, comprehensive urban approach is also to be given up in view of today's research realities, with an increasing amount of information and the growing transience of communication cycles on the one hand, and the only partially possible involvement of different

dimensions of thinking and a lavish diversity of perspectives and methodologies on the other. This is done in favor of a modest approach to an empirically rich urban research in the sense of a dense analysis that brings an understanding of each phenomenon as close as possible to the understanding of societal realities at that respective moment.

3. **Urban culture is thematically, methodologically, and epistemologically relevant.** Because urban cultural considerations offer themselves, first, *thematically* as attractive objects. For example, in cultural policy decisions, both built (material) as well as symbolic (immaterial) dimensions of urban development are combined. Also substantive dimensions of the production of meaning and knowledge in urban development can be traced with the aim of demonstrating the relevance of everyday life in cities in the sense of burgeoning cultural practices, latent needs, and requirements for migrants in receiving societies. *Methodologically* a diverse repertoire opens up, secondly, which draws its resources from practices such as sociology, political science, ethnology, and economics, as well as from the exploration of design, shape, and genuine aesthetics, changes in which are also an expression of civic unrest and societal change. Methodological innovations based on empirical reality are possible, especially when researchers as social actors understand the meaning of action research, which enables them to consciously reflect upon their own as well as foreign norms, values, and cultural backgrounds in the research process. The possible diversity of methods and the conflation of methodological variations (such as triangulation) can be understood not as an obstacle but rather as a prerequisite for postdisciplinary positioning in critical urban research. Thirdly, the approaches required by postdisciplinary research on urban cultural phenomena are offered *epistemologically* as committed spheres of intersection and resistance to friction, in order to expand concretely and make manageable the repertoire of relational concepts of space in architecture, landscape architecture, and planning departments. Because the urban phenomenon is a crowded social reality in a very small space, it is abstraction and concretization, projection, built reality, and everyday life in equal measure. For urban researchers the city is a potpourri of biographies and autobiographies, so to speak, and urban studies also needs to engage with this more than it has thus far.

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